It's not a cliche if you really mean it

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/65481001.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra)

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by Lisra

Summary

A collection of random stuff I did for SPOP Appreciation Week 2025!

Day 1: Remember/Memories - two poems
Day 2: Past, Present, Future - one poem
Day 3: A Beautiful Wish - minific
Day 4: You Are Not Alone - minific
Day 5: Imperfection Is Beautiful- minific
Day 6: Heart - one poem
Day 7: We're Going To Win In The End - minific/rambling

Remember/Memory

Catra:

"do you remember"

I always remember

every single deed

theirs and mine and yours

some fuel anger

some regret

some cause shivers

tears and snarling

some even pride

because I lived

with blood for blood

my own darkness outgrew theirs

until the need for shadows fled

and I saw clearly

creeping

from death's embrace

to yours

what needed to be done

I'll always remember

the final moment

when you stayed

this once

Adora:

memories?

Ever since the palace trap

they kept coming back

little things

bigger things

and seismic shifts that went

unnoticed in the shadows of those days

in high up places

alone with you and the black sky

talking

dreaming

dreams that were burned

and the ashes of war choked

all of my dreams until I saw

infected, dying, hopeless

you were still with me

calling me back

daring to share

a dream

Day 2: Past, Present, Future

Chapter Summary

Day 2: Past, Present, Future - one poem

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

the past is dead, it drowned

with pale eyes watching while

green slime crept ever closer

down my throat

around my heart

stilling loneliness, longing, fear

fear until the end

fear she'll come

fear she'll never come

fear of dying

self dissolving

everlasting pain

the pain is present the present is pain is present

myriad whisperings, countless voices

one set of eyes watching always watching always listening

through us, with us, in us, is us, always present

he is present

pain is present

shattered

mended

barely breathing

the ocean in your eyes, the halo of your hair

clutching

shaking

alone with my thoughts

but here with you

holding me

a new present

means there’s a future now

full of fear

but underneath

as I clutch and cry in your arms

there’s hope

Chapter End Notes

Thank you, really.

Day 3: A Beautiful Wish

Catra can't remember what she wished for in her past life. It had all been drowned in Horde Prime's pool. Under his dreadful eyes and against the chorus of his clones aspirations like ruling something as small and insignificant as the Horde withered and emotional delusions like finally putting Adora in her place were trampled.

After the waves of emotion that rushed over her after her apparent death and healing had left her in Adora's arms for a while, Catra didn't wish for a future either. The future only held things she wanted to avoid: People she had hurt, lives she had destroyed and bridges that had been burned. Knowing, *knowing* that it had not been entirely your own fault didn't matter. There had been many moments where she could have decided to act differently and she didn't. Thinking about that, dealing with that, were also things she had wanted to avoid. But most pressing of all, the pain of the chip that still was biting into her neck kept had kept her eyes on the dreadful present. Until Adora had barged in and, with the past looming behind, around and between them like a howling abyss full of hungry maws and blooded claws, she had grabbed for Adora's arm. And when she had seen She-Ra in her new glory, born not from the leavings of murderous progenitors but straight from Adora's heart, something had begun to stir inside Catra again.

Catra watches over Adora as she sleeps. The situation is dire, but when hasn't it been. She doesn't quite understand yet what is going on or what the plan is, or even if there is one. But she worries, worries so much, that the masked fiend that has entered their lives again is planning something bad. Catra will never trust Shadow Weaver and the Rebellion… well they are not too bad, she can now admit, but they don't have what it takes. Shadow Weaver will fool them again. Catra has to watch out for Adora, because she sure isn't looking out for herself. Catra worries so much that Melog wakes up and slinks over to her side, nudging their great head into her side. She scratches their head. There is

no need to speak. The strange creature knows what keeps her awake. Catra can’t forget the laughter and the gentle blush on Adora’s cheeks that she has seen more and more despite the ever worsening odds.

Catra does not wish for anything anymore, except to see the end of this battle with Adora and herself alive. What comes afterwards does not matter.

Adora’s face twitches in her sleep. Memories surface and Catra looks away for a second. Does Adora dream, does she wish for anything for herself, or is it all a wish for death so others can live?

Catra does not want to die. But she does not want to live without her anymore. But how can that wish ever come true?

Eventually even Catra sleeps and Melog watches over both of them.

Day 4: You Are Not Alone

Chapter Summary

A snippet from a prequel to my Black Metal AU.

The multiverse contains everything. Multiple times. That's just logic, and also profoundly unhelpful. Catra muses on this as she hides in the shadows of the bleachers. There must be plenty of universes where things are different, better even. Where Adora and Catra don't have shitty parents. Where they don't have scars they keep hidden from the very same parents lest they get some more. Maybe there's one where Adora sings in the church choir and Catra plays the organ, or one where Adora is the star quarterback and Catra the valedictorian. Surely, there must be one where they ride dragons into battle against the evil witch of the west (who is secretly Catra's mother) and where they have a gaggle of heroic friends who have their back.

But they live in this universe, where Catra has just heard the coach blow the final whistle. The girls will file off the playing field at last and Adora will change her uniform to the plain dress her father makes her wear. They will meet up at the bus stop and wait for the bus, both looking harmless and studious. They will hug for the socially acceptable amount of time when Catra gets off the bus first. None of these sad, small-minded, nasty *assholes* will ever know.

Catra picks up her backpack and its weight drives off the sad musings. There's the shirt and the album she got for Adora in there and most importantly, the letter she got yesterday. She'll slip it to her in the bus. It will blow her fucking mind. This woman they met in the bar two towns up the highway actually wrote to them. Catra briefly spoke to her on the phone – just to make sure the number was real. There is a plan now. No longer just a wish, a dream for a future. They will call Alice together on the weekend and make more plans. She's a weird one, that's for sure, but she's older than they are, she knows people, and she *wants to help.*

They won’t two girls who hold hands and listen to *“that satan music”* and play with third-hand and semi-stolen instruments in an abandoned building forever. They will skip this fucking town after graduation. They will go where no one knows them, wear their shirts openly, hold hands and one day, when they have a place to call their own, Catra will take off her nastiest band shirt and let Adora… she does not finish that thought. She still needs to sit next to her in the bus.

They aren’t two outsiders anymore. They are no longer alone.

Day 5: Imperfection Is Beautiful

Chapter Notes

> This may be the first time i actually used Hordak for something.

Hordak sits on top of a tower in the castle of Dryl. The country was utterly changed by the magic that ended the war. Were once only dry hills had been, there was now green everywhere. There had been some grumbling about that, but Hordak had found he liked to watch the green things grow. He was doing a lot of watching these days. He watched how the damage he and his armies had wrought was being undone. No one had asked him to help, or compelled him to do anything. But his inventions, their inventions really, were helping, even if people didn't know it. It was the least he could do. Mostly he watched the skies, especially at night when even the ever whirring and bustling castle calmed down. The other princesses probably wouldn't believe it, but Entrapta slept sometimes. The skies had countless stars and so many of them were connected to fading memories that weren't really his. Hordak could watch them fade, so to speak. He was looking forward to forgetting. His own crimes were bad enough without remembering everything that Prime had done.

He had watched the spectacle after the war from the sidelines, all the speeches, the celebrations, the cheering and the mourning, until the queen of Brightmoon had called for him. He had stood and bowed his head. There was nothing he wanted to say. He was sure there wasn't anything he could have said.

But he had not been alone. Always anxious in the spotlight, Entrapta had stood next to him, on her own legs, her hair woven protectively around him. She had told the multitudes what had happened, how he had remembered his own name, when he had seen her, how he had defied his creator in a brave but almost futile gesture to save her. It didn't make up for anything. It didn't

excuse anything. But it showed them, that he was not like him, that he could *care*.

Hordak cares a lot, about many things. Most things he never speaks about to anyone, but he cares in his heart. Now he tears his eyes away from the spectacle of light in the valley. As he stands up, his joints ache and the mechanical aids he needs strain. Maybe She-Ra could heal him too, but he will not ask. His body belongs to no one but himself now and it may be broken, but his little engineer always says that imperfections are beautiful. It took Hordak a long time to understand what that meant, but he is sure he understands now.

There's a strange noise from somewhere down below, indicating an interesting experimental failure of some sort. Hordak does something Horde Prime never could: He smiles.

Day 6: Heart

Chapter Notes

I'm sorry but it's more poetry today

What is the heart

the heart is a weapon

it circulates

life

blood

magic

and when it stops

you die

and your world dies with you

what is the heart

the heart is a machine

it has one job

it does it well

until it stops

but you are more than a machine

your worth is not your purpose

this heart is a weapon

your heart is not

but it’s infected

I can hear it beating

I can feel it slowing

can you hear me

feel me

my own heart

my own voice

calling

begging

hoping

another beat

another breath

in the heart of Etheria

as the weapon cracks

the magic breaks free

I see your eyes

open

your voice

answering

I feel your lips on mine

the rush of love

magic bursting all the dams

pulsing through you

unharmed

the magic ebbs

the tyrant falls

your heart is beating

you’re alive

your worth is not your purpose

I want to teach you

love you

hold you

we lived

your precious heart is beating

sound of my joy

Day 7: We're Going To Win In The End

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora could tell exactly when she had lost hope, although it took her many years and many long conversations to be able to do so. It came with Catra pulling the switch and opening the portal. The realization that they had drifted so far apart that Catra would end the world rather than lose the fight was too much. Adora had always maintained the hope Catra would see reason. And therein, she had much later seen, lay the problem.

She had not understood until it was too late. Her own role in driving Catra off, the vise of the system that had always squeezed them; not seeing the pain closest to her.

There were reasons. There were always reasons. Shadow Weaver, Hordak, the entire Horde structure, her own broken self-worth. Catra.

Adora understood in the end. That took a long time too, but they suddenly had all the time in the world to learn and heal. She had expected death, and got love instead. Some wounds couldn't really heal, some scars even magic can't fix, but the world is better now and if they can not fully heal, then can at least deal when necessary.

After the sword was broken and her power vanished, Adora had no hope left, but she went on, because she knew nothing else.

When she held Catra in her arms and felt life return to her, hope and come again too. It stood no chance against the grim need, the duty she perceived to die for others.

"I think I felt the same there, when I sent Glimmer through the teleporter, you know? I knew I was going to die and didn't care

because I could save her and you. I… I couldn't face it. Face you, I mean, and everything."

They held hands in the floating gardens of Mystacor. There was something in the strange way the sorcerers had sculpted everything in their floating realm that set thoughts and tongues in motion and encouraged people to talk.

"It's simple, isn't it," Adora whispered, squeezed her wife's hand for a moment, "everyone will remember how you saved them, mourn you and live on and all your mistakes no longer matter."

"Yeah," Catra agreed and looked down. Adora gently wrapped her arms around Catra, giving her ample time to decline closeness.

"You know how glad I am you didn't… die… really… back then. And I'm also glad you managed not to lose all hope. That we could still win in the end."

Catra nuzzled into Adora's neck.

"I had to hope until the end. No one's invincible and no one's perfect."

She stood in her tiptoes and pressed a kiss on Adora's lips.

"Only the way you kiss is perfect."

The stars shone above, their light broken by the magic bubble around Mystacor. Sometimes Adora wondered about the future. Would She-Ra continue after her? Would there ever be another threat like Horde Prime, a threat to sentient life itself? It wouldn't matter in the end. All empires fall, all tyrants die. There is always hope.

Chapter End Notes

This was the hardest prompt to write and I more than once thought about just doing a post about what this show and this fandom means to me. It doesn't surprise anyone that the answer is "a lot".

We also live in very scary times, with more people than ever threatened by the human driven scourges of war, famile and disease, while spurred on by humans mother nature also strikes hard. I have no big words, solutions or slogans to give, but I can only stress how important it is to not lose hope. For yourself, your friends, all the way up to our bonkers species.

All empires fall and all tyrants die. We must be strong and we must be brave. And I hope we are going to win in the end.

my deepest thanks to everyone involved with the show, all creators in the fandom who made such great visual and written art and to all the people in fandom who commented and showed me and one another kindness.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!